

COMPARE THE RESPONSIBILITIES BEFORE YOU APPLY

Product vs Project

Before you apply to a product or project manager opening, find out what you'd be responsible for. The titles sound similar, and the work overlaps, but you could spend much more of your week with customers in one job and coordinating delivery in the other.

Use the questions below to work out what the team needs, what experience you can bring, and whether you'd want the job.

1 Start with a decision the role would make

A product manager helps choose which customer problems to address, what to prioritize, and how to measure whether the product helped. A project manager organizes the work needed to deliver an agreed outcome, including the scope, schedule, resources, budget, and risks.

Both need judgment. The project manager can challenge an unrealistic plan, and the product manager still has to understand what the team can deliver.

EXAMPLE

Imagine a checkout redesign. The product manager might say, "Customers are leaving at payment. Let's test whether fewer steps help them finish." The project manager might say, "We need the payments team before testing can start. If they can't join this month, we need to change the date or reduce the work."

Ask the hiring manager, "What's a recent decision someone in this role made, and what did they need approval for?" Their answer tells you how much responsibility you'd have.

2 Ask what you would do each week

In a product role, you might interview customers, review usage data, write requirements, prioritize requests, and decide what to test next.

A project role could involve building the schedule, confirming who is doing what, reviewing costs, resolving delays, and keeping people informed when the plan changes.

EXAMPLE

"Can you walk me through a typical week for this role? How much time would I spend with customers, with the delivery team, and reporting progress?"

Listen for the work you'd actually enjoy doing. If you want customer research but the answer is mostly schedules and budget reviews, ask whether research is part of the job at all.

3 Look beyond software

Product management can cover software, hardware, and physical products. Project management also spans industries, including construction, healthcare, finance, and technology.

That gives you more places to look, but changing industries can mean learning different regulations, purchasing processes, or delivery methods. Experience with a software launch doesn't automatically prepare you to manage a construction project.

EXAMPLE

"Which parts of my experience would transfer here, and what industry knowledge would you expect me to have before joining?"

Search the titles in the locations and industries where you want to work. Compare the requirements before paying for a course or certification.

4 Check what the salary number includes

The reel uses rounded pay ranges. For a closer comparison, these are the source figures available for this guide on September 5, 2026:

Product manager: the Levels.fyi US snapshot shows \$168,000 to \$330,000 at the 25th to 75th percentiles, with median total compensation of \$230,000. Total compensation includes base salary, stock, and bonus.

Project manager: the Glassdoor US listing retrieved in search shows an estimated total-pay range of \$80,000 to \$138,000 and a median near \$105,000. It lists base pay separately at \$65,000 to \$110,000.

These aren't starting salaries or guaranteed limits. The Levels.fyi sample is tech-focused, and the Glassdoor listing covers a broader industry mix. They also combine different employers and experience levels. The roughly \$125,000 difference between those headline figures is not what a particular person would earn by switching jobs.

EXAMPLE

"What's the pay range for this opening at my level and location? Can you separate base salary, bonus, and stock?"

Compare those answers for the jobs you're considering. Check how the stock vests and whether the bonus is guaranteed before treating either as cash you can spend.

5 Find out where you can progress

Product roles can lead to senior product manager, group product manager, director, or VP positions. Project managers can progress into senior project, program, portfolio, or project management office leadership roles.

A project management office, or PMO, is a function, not a universal career limit. Titles and promotion routes vary by company. Ask what a more senior person owns there rather than assuming one job has a fixed stopping point.

EXAMPLE

"What changed in the work of the last person promoted from this role? Can someone keep progressing here without managing people?"

Ask which responsibility you'd need to demonstrate next. You'll have something specific to discuss when you set goals with your manager.

6 Prepare an example from your own work

Choose one project you can explain from start to finish. Write down what you personally did, which decisions you made, and what happened afterward.

For a product application, explain the customer problem, the evidence behind your recommendation, and how you checked the result. For a project application, describe how you planned the work, dealt with a risk or delay, and kept the people involved informed.

EXAMPLE

If your resume says "helped launch the new checkout," ask yourself, "Did I choose the problem, define requirements, coordinate delivery, or do some of each?" Replace "helped" with the part you can actually explain in an interview.

Use this checklist for each opening:

- ☐ What outcome would I be responsible for?
- ☐ Which decisions would I make?
- ☐ Who would I work with each week?
- ☐ What experience can I show with a real example?
- ☐ What do I still need to learn?
- ☐ What are the level, pay range, and promotion requirements?

If the description includes both product and project work, ask how the team divides those responsibilities. You don't have to guess from the title.

Sources: Levels.fyi US Product Manager snapshot captured September 5, 2026, and the Glassdoor US Project Manager search listing retrieved the same day. Glassdoor's full live page was unavailable during this revision. Recheck the current figures before using them in a negotiation.

<https://www.levels.fyi/t/product-manager?countryId=254>

https://www.glassdoor.com/Salaries/project-manager-salary-SRCH_K00,15.htm

Role descriptions: Atlassian's "Product manager" and "Project manager" guides. The dialogue and checkout example above are illustrative, not accounts of Dennis's work.